

CASCL 207
Sexuality in Ancient Greece & Rome
Fall 2026, TuTh 3:30PM - 4:45PM, CAS 218

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Office Hours: STH 435, W 10-11am and by appointment

This course examines cultural attitudes toward sex and gender in the Greek and Roman worlds through the study of ancient literary sources. We will explore how notions of masculinity and femininity structured Greco-Roman thought and produced normative representations of ancient men and women. We will also place special emphasis on gender-nonconforming individuals and non-normative forms of sexual desire: the richness and complexity of the ancient sources offer valuable evidence for alternative ways of being in the ancient world. Close readings of the primary sources will be framed by modern methodologies for the analysis of ancient cultures.

Required Texts

Hubbard, Thomas K., ed. *Homosexuality in Greece and Rome: A Sourcebook of Basic Documents*. Berkeley, Los Angeles, and London: University of California Press, 2003.
ISBN 978-0-520-23430-7

Morales, Helen, ed. *Greek Fiction: Callirhoe, Daphnis and Chloe, Letters of Chion*. Penguin Classics. ISBN 978-0140449259

Ormand, Kirk. *Controlling Desires: Sexuality in Ancient Greece and Rome*. Revised edition. Austin: University of Texas Press, 2018.

Assessment of Grades

45% Three essays (15% each)	A=93-100	A-=90-92	
25% Quizzes	B+=87-89	B=83-86	B-=80-82
15% Midterm exam	C+=77-79	C=73-76	C-=70-72
15% Final exam	D+=67-69	D=60-66	
	F=below 60		

BU Hub Learning Outcomes

Aesthetic Exploration

- We will read ancient Greek and Latin literary texts in English translation as a means of understanding how the cultural context of the works informs the views and conceptions of sexuality within them. We will also examine Classical Greek vase painting, statues, and paintings from Pompeii to understand how the ideas about sex and gender could be expressed through the visual repertoire of domestic and civic life in the ancient world.
- Understanding ancient ideas about sexuality as expressed in literary and visual works of art, students learn basic elements of literary and artistic interpretation. Key in this regard

will be genre and meter, rhetoric, intertextuality, and the semiotics of vase painting and other visual media.

- Students will write papers that analyze how various works of literature and visual art either exemplify or complicate our understanding of Greek or Roman sexuality. In order to properly analyze the artistic works, students will need to place the work in its proper historical and literary context and explain how its genre and style affect its presentation of sexuality.

Historical Consciousness

- The historical and chronological structure of the course will enable students to trace the development through time of Greek and Roman conceptions of sexuality. We will learn how changing political and social structures, from Archaic Greece through to Imperial Rome, affected the sexual lives and identities of the men, women, and children of ancient Greece and Rome.
- Much of the course is focused on the analysis of primary documents, ranging from poetry, to oratory, philosophy, history, inscriptions and visual art. In order to properly interpret any of these documents, students will first learn to situate them in their historical context.
- Learning about sexuality as a historically contingent phenomenon requires thinking about the sexual identities of different times and places in fundamentally new ways: the ancient Greeks and Romans did not conceive of sexual identity in the same ways that we do. Ancient conceptions of sexuality also relate to religious, moral, and philosophical beliefs, gender dynamics, and social distinctions between free and slave. Thus, in learning about how ancient conceptions of sexuality changed over time and also how vastly different they are from most modern conceptions, we will be learning about many aspects of ancient beliefs and social organization.

Critical Thinking

- This course will help you learn to recognize the difference between matters of fact and normative judgments and understanding how emotional responses can affect reasoning. It will be important to consider, for example, the different ways in which ancient Greek and Roman writers justified the morality of certain kinds of erotic or sexual relationships that our own society criticizes as morally problematic. We will discuss the difference between our own emotional and normative reactions to this material and a more objective approach that seeks to understand how ancient Greeks might have viewed the behavior within a different value system.
- You will be exposed to various modern critical theories of sexuality and will be asked to evaluate, both in class discussions and in written assignments, how constructivist theories of sexuality can help explain the vast differences between conceptions of sexuality in antiquity and in our own culture. I will also push you to think about limitations of such theories and what we might learn from theories that give a larger role to biological underpinnings of sexuality.

AI Policy

Use of AI in this course is prohibited. If I suspect that a student's written work has been produced using AI, I will request a one-on-one meeting with that student. The meeting must be in person. If during the meeting the student demonstrates comprehension of the target text(s) and relevant course material and can defend their written work, then they will receive full credit for the assignment and a grade appropriate to the quality of the work. If the student declines the meeting, or if during the meeting the student fails to defend their work, then I will report this as a violation of the academic conduct code and propose to the Dean as a penalty a failing grade (0) for the assignment in question. It is the responsibility of all students in the course to read and abide by the [academic conduct code](#).

Quizzes

There will be weekly quizzes. The point of these quizzes is to make sure that you are keeping up with the course reading assignments. These quizzes will be administered at the very beginning of class. The quizzes will be brief, consisting of four multiple choice questions (sometimes a bonus question), and will take no more than 5 minutes to complete. If you are late to class and miss the quiz, or if you are absent on a quiz day, you will **not** be allowed to take the quiz at another time or on another day. These missed quizzes simply will not be factored into your final grade. After two missed quizzes, each subsequent missed quiz will be factored as a zero (0) into your final grade. If you take every quiz, then I will drop your lowest quiz grade at the end of the semester.

Attendance Policy

Attendance is mandatory. Missing more than five classes without a valid excuse will automatically lower your base grade for the course to a C. Missing more than eight classes will automatically result in an F.

E-mail & Communication

If you have questions or concerns about an assignment, or if you would like to make an appointment to meet with me outside of class, the best way to contact me is by e-mail. **PLEASE KEEP YOUR E-MAILS BRIEF AND PROFESSIONALLY COURTEOUS.** If I need to contact you outside of class about upcoming assignments or changes in the course schedule, I will send group e-mails from BB to your official Boston University e-mail accounts. **IT IS YOUR RESPONSIBILITY TO CHECK YOUR BU E-MAIL DAILY.**

Content Warning

The study of literature encompasses the human experience and thus regularly also deals with difficult topics that some students might find upsetting or uncomfortable. In this course, such topics include, but are not limited to, the following:

- misogyny
- homophobia
- transphobia
- violence
- self-harm and suicide
- sexual assault
- rape
- slavery

We discuss these topics to understand them and to analyze how literary expression from different historical and cultural contexts offers an artistic medium for critical engagement with all human experience, including traumatic realities. Meaningful participation and success in this course will require your willingness and ability to confront any such issues in an open, honest, and safe academic setting. If at any time during the semester the course material makes you feel uncomfortable, it is your responsibility to contact the instructor immediately, either in person or by email, to discuss a reasonable accommodation. Students who find these conditions threatening to their emotional well-being should consider an alternative course of study. Students with concerns about the content of any of the works are invited to consult online plot summaries and reviews in order to assess any risk they might anticipate in the reading and discussion of the assigned works.

Schedule of Assignments (subject to change)

BB = Blackboard

CD = Ormand, *Controlling Desires: Sexuality in Ancient Greece and Rome*

GF = *Greek Fiction: Callirhoe, Daphnis & Chloe, Letters of Chion*

HGR = Hubbard (ed.), *Homosexuality in Greece and Rome*

Week 1

Th Sept 3 Introduction

Week 2

T Sept 8 Ormand, "Introduction" (CD pp. 1-24)
Homer, *Iliad*, Book 1 (BB)

Th Sept 10 Homer, *Iliad*, Books 3 & 6 (BB)

Week 3

T Sept 15 Ormand, "Homer, Hesiod, and Greek Lyric Poetry" (CD pp. 25-54)
Homer, *Iliad* Book 14 (BB)

Th Sept 17 [Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite](#)

Week 4

T Sept 22 No Class: Smith in Athens

Th Sept 24 No Class: Smith in Athens

Week 5

T Sept 29 [Hesiod, Theogony](#)
Genesis 1-3 (BB); Pandora section from Hesiod, *Works & Days* (BB); Zeitlin,
"The Economics of Hesiod's Pandora" (BB)
WRITING DAY

Th Oct 1 Archaic Greek Lyric (HGR pp. 21-54)

Week 6

T Oct 6 Ormand, "Sexual Roles and Sexual Rules in Classical Athens" (*CD* pp. 55-72)
Aeschines, *Against Timarchus* (*HGR* 131-153)

Th Oct 8 Ormand, "Legal and Illegal Sex in Ancient Greece" (*CD* 92-110)
[*Against Neaera*](#)

Week 7

T Oct 13 No class: Monday schedule

Th Oct 15 Greek Historical Texts (*HGR* pp. 55-85)
Ormand, "Philosophical Sex" (*CD* pp. 111-129)

Week 8

T Oct 20 Plato, *Symposium* (*HGR* pp. 180-207)
Ormand, "Greek Pots and Greek Sex" (*CD* pp. 130-155)

Th Oct 22 **Midterm exam**

Week 9

T Oct 27 Ormand, "Love and Sex in Hellenistic Poetry" (*CD* 156-181)
Hellenistic Poetry (*HGR* pp. 268-307)

Th Oct 29 Ormand, "Rome and Roman Sex" (*CD* pp. 182-201)
Ormand, "Roman Poetry about Love and Sex" (*CD* pp. 247-278)
Catullus (*HGR* pp. 308-311, 326-335)

Week 10

T Nov 3 Vergil, *Aeneid*, Book 1 (BB)

Th Nov 5 Vergil, *Aeneid*, Book 4 (BB)
WRITING DAY

Week 11

T Nov 10 Ovid, selections from *Metamorphoses* (*HGR* pp. 373-381)
Ormand, "Excursus: Lesbians in Ovid's *Metamorphoses*" (*CD* pp. 279-292)

Th Nov 12 Ormand, "Roman Sex on the Walls and in Gardens" (*CD* pp. 293-322)

Week 12

T Nov 17 Chariton, *Callirhoe* Books 1-3 (*GF* pp. 3-38)

Th Nov 19 Chariton, *Callirhoe* Books 4-5 (*GF* pp. 39-72)

Week 13

T Nov 24 Chariton, *Callirhoe* Books 6-8 (*GF* pp. 73-134)

Th Nov 26 No class

Week 14

T Dec 1 Longus, *Daphnis & Chloe*, Book 1 (*GF* pp. 137-154)
WRITING DAY

Th Dec 3 Longus, *Daphnis & Chloe*, Book 2 (*GF* pp. 155-172)
Longus, *Daphnis & Chloe*, Book 3 (*GF* pp. 173-190)

Week 15

M Dec 8 Longus, *Daphnis & Chloe*, Book 4 (*GF* pp. 191-210)

W Dec 10 Wrap-up

Th Dec 17 Final Exam, 3-5pm